

# The Journey to the Land of Youth

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, an old, bright salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is full of ideas, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.*

### Before you begin

A small friend of the village has gone missing. Yesterday they ran after a white deer, down to the Misty Loch and across the water, into the Land of Youth. That is the gentle Otherworld, once called Tir na nOg, where no one ever grows old. It is a lovely place. That is the danger. The longer your friend stays there, the more they forget the way home.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver calls you to her side. "You two have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she says. "Will you cross the mist and bring our friend gently home, before they forget us altogether?"

She gives you three gifts: a sprig of oak for luck, a honey oatcake to share, and a ball of red wool. Then she smiles. "Here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Imagination, of Courage, or of Kindness?*

### Stop 1 The Salmon's Riddle

You come down to the shore of the Misty Loch. The water is grey and still. How will you ever cross?

Then a great silver fish rises up in the ripples. It is the Salmon of Wisdom, old and bright and kind. "I know the way across," he says, "and I will tell you, if you can answer my riddle."

★ *Could you listen closely and think it through together? A brave, thoughtful guess is allowed too. Try something and see.*

When you answer, the salmon swishes his tail in the water. "Well thought," he says. He shows you where to wait for the boat.

### Stop 2 The Selkie's Crossing

By the reeds waits Sorchla the Selkie, a gentle seal-person in a soft grey cloak. She has a little wooden boat. But she is shy, and she looks a little lonely, and she will not quite meet your eyes.

★ *This is not a thing to win by force. How could you be kind to her? You could give her a warm word. You could share your honey oatcake. What do you try?*

When you are kind, Sorchla smiles for the first time in a long while. "Climb in," she says softly. She rows you out into the mist, and on the far side waits the Land of Youth.

### Stop 3 The Land of Youth

You step ashore into the Otherworld. The apple trees are all in blossom, the light is golden, and there is your friend, laughing in the flowers. But when you call their name, they only half remember you. "Stay," they say. "Stay here forever. It is always lovely here."

It would be easy to stay. That is the danger. But you remember home: the warm Roundhouse, the people who love you, the way the loch shines at dawn.



*This is not a fight. How will you help your friend remember home? You could tell them about home until they smile. You could tie the red wool so you can all find the way back. What do you do?*

Gently, kindly, you help your friend remember. Their eyes clear. "Home," they say. "Yes. Let's go home together." You tie the red wool tight, and you all choose, together, to return.

### Home Across the Mist

Sorcha is waiting in her boat, and she rows you all back across the water, following the red wool home. The mist parts. There is the green shore, bright in the morning sun, your friend safe and smiling beside you.

You came home together, and you have a selkie friend now too. High on the green hills, Danu the Kind smiles down at you. You did it. You were brave, you were kind, and most of all, you were full of ideas. Well done, heroes.

# The Journey to the Land of Youth: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the whole game works; read it first if this is new. This page holds only what is special about this story. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, set in the misty Otherworld with its quiet pull to stay forever, but good ideas and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

## Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the home loch shore.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a twig or leaf for the sprig of oak, a small cake or token for the honey oatcake, and a ball of string or red wool. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

## The Twist of Fate

Once at each place the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

| Roll | Twist of Fate                                                      |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Pook the Puca pops up and gives you one free hint.                 |
| 2    | You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.        |
| 3    | A soft breeze drifts off the loch, and the next challenge is Easy. |
| 4    | The Salmon of Wisdom blows a lucky bubble. All is well.            |
| 5    | A sprig of oak for luck: keep one roll to use again later.         |
| 6    | A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.        |

## How it ends

There is no foe in this tale and nothing to defeat. The only danger is the gentle pull of the Land of Youth, the temptation to stay forever in that lovely, forgetful place. The story is won not by beating anyone but by remembering home: the heroes gently help their half-forgetful friend recall the people and hearth waiting for them, tie the red wool so all can find the way back, and choose, kindly and together, to return across the mist. Let that choosing land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

# The Journey to the Land of Youth: Puzzles and Solutions

*For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.*

## Stop 1: The Salmon's Riddle (Normal)

**The challenge.** The Salmon of Wisdom will not show the way across the Misty Loch until the players answer his riddle. He is fair and kind, and he wants them to do well.

**The riddle.** Read it aloud: *"I am not a bird, and yet I fly. I have no wings, yet I cross the sky. I cannot be caught and I cannot be kept, and I am gone the moment you turn to look. What am I?"* The answer is **the mist** (or a cloud, which the salmon accepts just as gladly, since both drift over the loch).

**Intended solution.** This is a thinking challenge of Imagination and a little patience. Let the children talk it through together. The salmon accepts the right answer, and because he is kind, he also accepts a brave, thoughtful guess.

**Fallback.** If they are stuck, the salmon offers a clue ("You have walked through me all morning, and you cannot hold me in your hand"), or Pook the Puca whispers the answer from the reeds. A guess made bravely still earns the way across.

**Make it simpler.** For a little one, point around and ask, "What floats over the loch that we can walk through but never hold?" Pointing at the mist is the whole answer.

## Stop 2: The Selkie's Crossing (Normal)

**The challenge.** Sorcha the Selkie has the only boat, but she is shy and a little lonely and will not meet the heroes' eyes. They must win her trust to be ferried across the mist. This is never won by force or by demanding.

**Intended solution.** This is a Kindness and Courage moment. Any genuine warmth works: a gentle word, telling her she is not alone, asking her name, or sharing the **honey oatcake**. It takes a little courage to speak first to a shy stranger. When the children are kind, Sorcha smiles, takes up the oars, and rows them across.

**Fallback.** If the children freeze or are unsure what to say, have Sorcha sniffle softly and murmur, "Nobody ever stops to talk to me." A single kind word melts her shyness. Sharing even a crumb of the oatcake counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

**Make it simpler.** For a little one, just ask them to wave and say "hello, would you like to be friends?" That one friendly hello is enough to win Sorcha over.

## Stop 3: The Land of Youth (Hard, then no roll)

**The challenge.** In the ever-blossoming Otherworld the heroes find their lost friend, but the friend has half-forgotten home and gently urges everyone to stay forever. The pull to stay is the only danger, and the players may feel it too. There is nobody to defeat.

**Intended solution.** This is a Kindness and Imagination moment. The good, kind move is to give the friend their home back: talk warmly about the Roundhouse, the people who love them, the home loch at dawn, until the memory returns. Tying the **ball of red wool** at the water's edge is the bright idea that lets them all retrace the way back through the mist. When the friend remembers, everyone chooses, together, to return. After that choice there is no roll: the way home is simply taken.

**Fallback.** If the children are unsure, have the friend pause and ask, very quietly, "Wait... was there someone who used to sing to me at night?" Any warm memory the children offer brings the friend the rest of the way back. The red wool guarantees nobody loses the path, however misty it grows.

**Make it simpler.** For a little one, ask them to name one person at home they love and miss; saying that one name is enough to help the friend remember and choose home.

## The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the friend remembers and chooses home, Sorcha ferries them all back across the loch by the trail of red wool, the mist parts on a bright green shore, and **Danu the Kind** smiles down from the hills. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas, and by keeping their promise to bring their friend home.

# Wander and Tales

## Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Version 6.0, updated 2026-06-06, en-GB



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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.